

On Two Types of Mood Shift in Icelandic Conditionals

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Abstract. Ordinarily, the finite verb of Icelandic "o-marked" conditional *ef*-protases occurs in the indicative. However, subjunctive finite verbs are obligatory under "conditional inversion," i.e., in V1-protases, and they occasionally show up in present tense *ef*-protases. In this squib, interpretive consequences of these two types of "conditional mood shift" – referred to as CMS_1 and CMS_2, respectively – are characterized. Thus, CMS_1 may lead to "neutralization" of perfect semantics, where a present perfect subjunctive has to stand in for a past indicative, and to outright unacceptability if the main verb is a reportively used form of *kveða* ("say," "speak"). CMS_2 is interpretively neutral in some instances but appears to allow "potentialis" uses like its historical precursor in Old Norse in others. An analysis is sketched for CMS_1, drawing on a competition approach to the semantics of the perfect.

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1. CMS_1

In a plea for terminological clarity, Iatridou (2021:125) calls attention to the paradigm from Icelandic in (1) to argue that the subjunctive marking of conditionals does not necessarily lead to counterfactual construal (cf. von Stechow and Iatridou 2023:1470).

(1) a. *Ef hann hefur farið, kem ég.*

if he have.PRS.IND gone, come I

'If he has left, I will come.'

b. *Hafi hann farið, kem ég.*

have.PRS.SUBJ he gone come I

'If he has left, I will come.'

c. **Ef hann hafi farið ...*

if he have.PRS.SUBJ gone

d. **Hefur hann farið ...*

have.PRS.IND he gone

Thus, in Icelandic, "conditional inversion," i.e., V°_{fin} -to- C° (via I°) in the conditional protasis, requires the finite verb to be realized as subjunctive. In the following, this kind of conversion involved in relating indicative *ef*-conditionals to formally subjunctive V1-conditionals will be called "Conditional Mood Shift_1" (CMS_1).

Interestingly, Iatridou (ibid.) comments on the apparent semantic vacuity of CMS_1, noting that "[i]t is unclear what the difference in meaning is between [(1a)] and [(1b)], or even if there is one to begin with." And indeed, absence of interpretive effects is supported by the matter-of-course description of and lack of further elaboration on CMS_1 in the literature (cf. Friðjónsson 1978:240; Kress 1982:257; Thráinsson 1986:173).¹ Since, however, illustrations have tended to use indicative *ef*-clauses in the present tense as "input," a number of striking complications brought into play by past indicatives have gone unnoticed. Concretely, CMS_1 sometimes necessitates "collateral" semantic adjustments in order to be meaning preserving, and it may even result in outright unacceptability. Two examples of the former and one of the latter kind will be provided in the following. First, consider the pair of sentences in (2).²

- (2) a. *Ef María var í Danmörku í gær, er hún í dag á Íslandi.*
 if Mary be.PST.IND in Denmark yesterday is she today on Iceland
 'If Mary was in Denmark yesterday, she is in Iceland today.'
- b. **Væri María í Danmörku í gær, er hún í dag á Íslandi.*
 be.PST.SUBJ Mary in Denmark yesterday is she today on Iceland
 (*) 'Were Mary in Denmark yesterday, she is in Iceland today.'

In line with what Grønn (2021:235; cf. Sæbø 2023:320) calls "tense transposition," morphologically past subjunctives like *væri* ('were') fail to trigger a temporal "backshift," being interpreted as semantic non-pasts rather than pasts (cf. Iatridou 2000:6.1, and Section 3

below). In the case of (2b), this leads to a clash with the past time adverbial *í gær* ('yesterday'). The literal English translation directly replicates this effect. Instead, to turn (2a) into a V1-conditional, Icelandic has to resort to the (present) perfect, (3a), given that CMS_1 cannot be suspended, (3b).

- (3) a. *Hafi María verið í Danmörku í gær, er hún í dag á Íslandi.*
 have.PRS.SUBJ Mary been in Denmark yesterday is she today on Iceland
 'If Mary was in Denmark yesterday, she is in Iceland today.'
- b. **Var María í Danmörku í gær, er hún í dag á Íslandi.*
 be.PST.IND Mary in Denmark yesterday is she today on Iceland

Now, importantly, the Icelandic present perfect gives rise to the same "puzzle" as its English counterpart (cf. Klein 1992) in that it cannot combine with past time adverbials. Like the Mainland Scandinavian languages (cf. Haugen 1972), however, Icelandic does allow the incriminated configuration under an inferential evidential interpretation (Giorgi and Pianesi 1997:119; Jónsson 1992:137; Larsson 2008:56,fn.5, 57; Thráinsson 2017:128). The latter is illustrated in (4).

- (4) *María hefur [PRS.IND] verið í Danmörku í gær.*
 'Mary will have been in Denmark yesterday.'

Yet no such constraint applies in the case of V1-conditionals, as shown in (3a). Replacing the past by the perfect under CMS_1 preserves the meaning of the former.

Second, the Icelandic simple past and present perfect (tend to) differ semantically in ways again similar to English. Thus, in order to strictly locate an eventuality in the past one has to use the former, while the present perfect – on its "universal" reading (cf. Jónsson 1992) –

serves to convey continuation up to utterance time (cf. Friðjónsson 1978:81). This effect can be brought out with the help of durative adverbials such as *í mörg ár* ('for many years'):

- (5) a. *Ef Sigurður var alvarlega veikur í mörg ár,*
 if Sigurð be.PST.IND seriously ill in many years
hvernig stendur á því að hann er fullkomlega frískur núna?
 how stands on it that he is entirely healthy now
 'If Sigurð was seriously ill for many years,
 how come he is in perfect health now?'
 b. #*Ef Sigurður hefur [PRS.IND] verið alvarlega veikur í mörg ár,*
hvernig stendur á því að hann er fullkomlega frískur núna?

The conditional protasis in (5b) implies that Sigurð has been seriously ill for many years (up to utterance time), which is inconsistent with the presupposition of the consequent question. But once more, strikingly, this semantic contribution of the perfect gets obliterated under CMS_1, as evidenced by the fact that (6) preserves the pragmatic felicity of (5a).³

- (6) *Hafi [PRS.SUBJ] Sigurður verið alvarlega veikur í mörg ár,*
hvernig stendur á því að hann er fullkomlega frískur núna?

Third, as pointed out by Thráinsson (2019:627,fn.11), the Icelandic verb *kveða* ('say,' 'speak') can be used as a semantically present reportive marker ('is said,' 'is alleged'), but only if it is formally realized as past tense. This is exemplified in (7).

- (7) *Ef sjálfur bréfberinn kvað vera milljónamæringur,*
 if self postman say.PST.IND be millionaire

hvað segir það okkur um áreiðanleika sögusagna?

what says it us about reliability rumor.GEN.PL

'If even the postman is said to be a millionaire,

what does that tell us about the reliability of rumors?'

However, remarkably, this time CMS_1 stands in the way of producing any kind of V1-counterpart, as the unacceptability of all variants in (8) indicates.

(8) a. *Hafi sjálfur bréfberinn kveðið vera milljónamæringur,

have.PRS.SUBJ self postman said be millionaire

hvað segir það okkur um áreiðanleika sögusagna?

'If even the postman is said to be a millionaire,

what does that tell us about the reliability of rumors?'

b. *Kvæði [PST.SUBJ] sjálfur bréfberinn vera milljónamæringur, ...

c. *Kveði [PRS.SUBJ] sjálfur bréfberinn vera milljónamæringur, ...

d. *Kveður [PRS.IND] sjálfur bréfberinn vera milljónamæringur, ...

Since no past interpretation is involved in (8), the perfect in (8a) may not be called for in the first place. This would bring in the simple past subjunctive as preferable, but still, (8b) is ruled out. Likewise, a switch to present tense forms does not remedy the situation, as shown by (8c) and (8d), with the latter illustrating once more that CMS_1 has to remain in force. It thus turns out that the reportive reading of *kveða* is strictly bound to a past indicative form.⁴

2. CMS_2

Further light can be cast on the paradigm in (1) and the vagaries of mood choice in Icelandic conditionals by noting that the unacceptability of (1c) is not categorical. As reported in the

literature (e.g., Thórðardóttir 2006; 2012; 2017; Thráinsson 2007:405), replacing present indicatives by present subjunctives in *ef*-protases does occur and seems to become more common, particularly among younger speakers. (9) shows a corpus example (from a user manual).⁵

(9) %*Ef það sé gulbrúnt, þá er rafhlaðan að hlaðast.*

if it be.PRS.SUBJ yellow.brown then is battery.the to charge

'If it [the light] is amber, then the battery is charging.'

Thus, given that the protasis in (9) standardly requires *er* instead of *sé*, one can speak of a(n optional) [PRS.IND]>[PRS.SUBJ]-shift affecting Modern Icelandic *ef*-conditionals. This will be called "Conditional Mood Shift_2" (CMS_2).

Importantly, the *ef*-clause in (9) seems to provide an entirely neutral description of a "suppositional" state of affairs, i.e., there is no noticeable difference in meaning wrt its canonical indicative counterpart. This is in contrast with historical precursors of CMS_2, a few of which have been noted for Old Norse (cf. Hildebrand 1871:59). Consider (10).⁶

(10) *Nálgastu mik, ef þú megir*

come.near.IMP.you me if you can.PRS.SUBJ

'Approach me, if you can!'

Here, *megir* can be considered a "potentialis" use of the present subjunctive (e.g., von Kutschera 1974:258): the speaker avoids more neutral expression of the protasis proposition via the indicative, choosing to signal non-standard possibility or diminished likelihood instead. More concretely, in a context of antagonistic verbal exchange (cf. Bax and Padmos

1983), the protagonist Odin amplifies an act of provocation, threat, and intimidation by casting doubt on his addressee's, King Geirrøðr's, capabilities to defend his own life.

Now, arguably, similar kinds of construal motivate at least some instances of CMS_2 (cf. Thráinsson 2007:405,fn.7). (11), taken over from Thórðardóttir (2006:58), is a case in point.

(11) %*Ef ég sé með hattinn kemst ég örugglega í stuð.*

if I be.PRS.SUBJ with hat.the get I surely in excellent.mood

'If I'm wearing the hat, I'm surely going to feel great.'

Through the use of present subjunctive *sé*, the speaker would be able to convey being uncertain or undecided as to whether or not to wear the hat in the first place. It would thus contribute to a particular "variant of iffiness" (cf. Kaufmann, Kaufmann and Hinterwimmer 2025; building on work by von Fintel and Iatridou 2003).⁷ Pending further investigation, though, this interpretive option for CMS_2 must be left a matter of conjecture. At the same time, from a broader perspective, CMS_2 is in line with ideas about a reorganization of the Icelandic mood system (cf. Gaertner and Eythórsson 2020) according to which the use of indicatives gets restricted to environments supporting speaker commitments (cf. Árnason 1981:171; Sigurðsson 1990:322; Thráinsson and Thórðardóttir 2015:178,fn.2) and subjunctives function as elsewhere case.⁸

3. Analysis

Although a full-fledged analysis is beyond the current squib, some remarks are in order on how to approach CMS on more principled grounds. Due, however, to the more preliminary state of our research on CMS_2, we will here concentrate on CMS_1.

To begin with, it is useful to stress that past subjunctive forms are the canonical means of "x-marking" in the sense of von Fintel and Iatridou (2023) in Icelandic (Sigurðsson 2010:43;

von Fintel and Iatridou 2023:1470). And, importantly, that function, accompanied by the already mentioned absence of temporal backshift, cannot be overruled just for the sake of complying with the condition on V1-protases, as shown by (2b). This issue is non-trivial in Icelandic with its comprehensive subjunctive paradigms and intricate mixture of idiosyncratic and regular (mostly sequence-of-tense-driven) occurrences of subjunctives in subordinate clauses (e.g., Kress 1982; Sigurðsson 2010:3.3; Thráinsson 2007:8.1).

Next, key to explaining the consequences of CMS_1 is coming to grips with what may be called the "perfectum-pro-paeterito"-effect in (2). This phenomenon has otherwise been taken for granted in descriptive grammars, namely, as an innocuous by-product of direct-to-indirect speech transposition. The example in (12) is by Einarsson (1949:157), who doesn't deem the meaning preserving nature of (12b) worth mentioning.

(12) a. DS: *Hún kom [PST.IND] heim í gær.*

'She came home yesterday.'

b. IS: *Hann segir, að hún hafi [PRS.SUBJ] komið heim í gær.*

'He says that she came home yesterday.'

Now, strikingly, substitutions of that kind fit quite well into, and may serve as further evidence for, competition models of the relation between simple past and present perfect, such as promoted by researchers like Stump (1985) and Schaden (2009) (see also Grønn and von Stechow 2021:2.4, 2.5, 4; and Portner 2011:2.3.4 for the more general debate). To show this, let us, for ease of exposition, follow Stump (1985:228) and introduce what he terms "perfect intervals:" "any interval which begins earlier than some interval *i* and lasts no later than *i* is to be a *perfect interval* relative to *i*." This is formally represented by the following

constant (cf. Stump 1985:232), assuming in addition that "at any interval *i*, **now** denotes *i*" (ibid.:101):

$$(13) \quad [[\mathbf{perf}(t)]] = \exists t_1[t_1 \subseteq t \wedge t_1 < \mathbf{now}] \wedge \neg \exists t_2[t_2 \subseteq t \wedge \mathbf{now} < t_2]$$

Crucially, (13) combines the "anteriority analysis" (Grønn and von Stechow 2021:3.1) and the "extended now analysis" (ibid.:3.3) of the (semantics of the) perfect. As a result, both past intervals and extended nows are perfect intervals, given their (simplified and adapted) specification in (14) (cf. Stump 1985:101, 225).

$$(14) \quad \text{a. } [[\mathbf{past}(t)]] = t < \mathbf{now}$$

$$\text{b. } [[\mathbf{xn}(t)]] = \mathbf{now} \subset t \wedge \neg \exists t_1[t_1 \subseteq t \wedge \mathbf{now} < t_1]$$

Substitution effects are then enabled if the "function of the perfect is to locate an event within a perfect interval" (Stump 1985:228). And, in particular, since past intervals are subcases of perfect intervals, the "normal" perfect becomes semantically compatible with past time adverbials like *í gær* ('yesterday'), as required for cases like (3a) and (12b). (Given $\text{YESTERDAY}(t) \rightarrow [t < \mathbf{now}]$, both conjuncts in (13) can be satisfied such that $\text{YESTERDAY}(t) \rightarrow \mathbf{perf}(t)$ will hold as well.) Incompatibility, on the other hand, is taken to arise as a matter of "blocking" in exactly those environments where the simple past is a competitor of the perfect, e.g., the "plain," i.e., non-inferential, version of (4).

The second essential ingredient of an account is a constraint on conditional protases that links the filling of C° and the choice of verbal mood. This is stated in schematic form in (15), with the "attractor" of the finite verb specified as in (15a) and (15b/c) showing (part of) the

featural make-up of Standard Icelandic *ef*. (For one way of how to develop this further, see Biberauer and Roberts 2017).

- (15) a. $\emptyset: [\text{COND}] > [\text{SUBJ}]$
 b. *ef*: $[\text{COND.O}] >_{\text{d}} [\text{IND}]$
 c. *ef*: $[\text{COND.X}] > [\text{PST.SUBJ}]$

(15a) strictly enforces CMS_1 for all V1-protases. For *ef*-clauses it is advantageous to follow von Fintel and Iatridou (2023) more fully and distinguish "o-marked" ($\approx$ "realis") from the earlier mentioned x-marked ($\approx$ "irrealis") instances. Regarding the former, it has to be emphasized that the indicative requirement of *ef* in (15b) is only a default ($>_{\text{d}}$), which can be "overwritten" in reportive environments.⁹ (15c), on the other hand, states that x-marked *ef*-protases have to come with the said canonical markers, i.e., formally past subjunctive finite verbs.

Third, matters of concord aside (for "tense agreement" in Icelandic, see Sigurðsson 2010:52f.; 2016; Thráinsson 2005:153), the temporal interpretation of Icelandic subjunctive forms shows the familiar split (e.g., Thieroff 2004): present subjunctives behave like their indicative counterparts, which implies that present perfects introduce **perf**, whereas past subjunctives fail to themselves trigger a backshift, i.e., technically speaking, they come without **past**.¹⁰

With the above building blocks in place, we are able to derive the patterns discussed in Section 1. (1c) [** Ef hann hafi [PRS.SUBJ] farið, ...*] violates the indicative default in (15b), assuming that it does not form part of a larger reportive environment and that we are not dealing with an "innovative" use of the kind responsible for CMS_2. (1d) [** Hefur [PRS.IND] hann farið, ...*] is ruled out by the strict subjunctivity constraint imposed on conditional V1-

protases by (15a). The unacceptability of (2b) [* Væri [PST.SUBJ] *María í Danmörku í gær*, ...] is due to *í gær* ('yesterday') requiring a semantically past prejacents, which *væri* ('were') cannot induce. And, attempts at repairing this via (3b) [* Var [PST.IND] *María í Danmörku í gær*, ...] falter on (15a) again. (Past perfect V1-protases [Hefði [PST.SUBJ] *María verið* ... 'Had Mary been ...'] involve past subjunctive auxiliaries, due to (15a), and thus end up x-marked.)

The more subtle interpretive effects in (5) and (6), then, will have to be dealt with in terms of blocking. Note first that both (5a) [Ef *Sigurður var* [PST.IND], ...] and (5b) [# Ef *Sigurður hefur* [PRS.IND] *verið*, ...] comply with the indicative default of o-marked *ef*-protases stated in (15b). Thus, we are dealing with a structure where simple past and present perfect compete. Also, given that the overall meaning of (5) requires placing the period of Sigurð's serious illness properly in the past, use of the form that directly encodes this – i.e., simple past *var* ('was') via (14a) – pre-empts use of the form that does not unambiguously do so. The present perfect *hefur verið* ('has been') locates the illness within a perfect interval, via (13), and, due to the superset/subset relation between perfect and past intervals, standard mechanisms of blocking (cf. Stump 1985:233f.) kick in: deliberate choice of the broader, and avoidance of the narrower, form signals that a different kind of perfect interval fits the descriptive intentions of the speaker, one that reaches into the non-past region, i.e., an extended now. This, however, is incompatible with the meaning of the apodosis, according to which Sigurð's illness no longer pertains at the time of utterance. Hence the infelicity of (5b). By contrast, such signaling is absent from (6), where – as illustrated above for (2b)/(3b) – no simple past competitor is available. As a consequence, a plain anteriority reading of the present perfect goes through and we derive the "perfectum-pro-*praeterito*" effect.¹¹

Now, as already pointed out by Stump himself (1985:235), a purely pragmatic blocking mechanism might not be considered strong enough for capturing the "present perfect puzzle." To repeat, the non-inferential version of Icelandic (4) has the same status as its English

counterpart (*/# *Mary has been in Denmark yesterday.*).¹² However, since we have nothing substantial to add to this debate, we'll leave it at noting that alternative approaches are to be judged by how successfully (and insightfully) they deal with the compatibility of past time adverbials like *yesterday* with all the other perfects, i.e., with non-finite and past (cf. Stump 1985:230f.) as well as the Icelandic "pro-praeterito" ones.

Finally, the ban on a reportive construal of *kveða* ('say') in (8) can, technically, be dealt with by a separate lexical entry such as (16), which, in addition to introducing ingredients of a raising analysis, assigns reportivity exclusively to [PST.IND] forms.¹³

(16) *kveða*_{REP}: $\langle V_{[PST.IND]}[\bullet IP_{[-FIN][-að]\bullet}], \lambda p[IT.IS.SAID.THAT(p)] \rangle$

For the sake of completeness, it should be pointed out as a reminder that a V1-counterpart of the *ef*-protasis in (7), [** Kvað* [PST.IND] *sjálfur bréðberinn vera milljónamæringur, ...*], would fail to comply with subjunctivity, (15a). Partial "ineffability" thus follows.

4. Conclusion

This squib has concerned itself with the marking of verbal mood in conditional protases of Icelandic. In particular, two kinds of deviation from the indicative default in o-marked *ef*-protases have been focused on: (i) Obligatory subjunctives under "conditional inversion," i.e., in V1-protases, and (ii) subjunctives occasionally arising in present tense *ef*-protases.

Interpretive consequences of these two types of "conditional mood shift" – referred to as CMS_1 and CMS_2, respectively – have been characterized. Thus, CMS_1 has been shown to lead to "neutralization" of perfect semantics, where a present perfect subjunctive has to stand in for a past indicative – the "perfectum-pro-praeterito" effect, and to outright unacceptability if the main verb is a reportively used form of *kveða* ('say,' 'speak'). It has

further tentatively been suggested that CMS_2 is interpretively neutral in some instances but may have "potentialis" uses, and thus contribute to a particular "variant of iffiness" (Kaufmann, Kaufmann and Hinterwimmer 2025; von Fintel and Iatridou 2003), like its historical precursor in Old Norse.

An analysis has been sketched for CMS_1, drawing on the semantic approach to the perfect by Stump (1985), which defines a superset/subset relation between perfect and past intervals and through this enables the induction of substitution and blocking effects in environments of (non-)competition between simple pasts and present perfects.

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¹ There are differences between *if*-conditionals and V1-conditionals that arise independently of verbal mood. The relevant phenomena documented for Icelandic by Iatridou (ibid.:fn.8; citing Iatridou and Embick 1994) can in large part also be found in German (cf. Reis and Wöllstein 2010), a language without CMS₁.

² Verbal morphology is only made explicit for relevant items. In the remaining cases, it can, however, be straightforwardly recovered from unanalyzed English glosses.

³ An analogous argument can be made in terms of a suspended "life-time effect" (cf. Schaden 2009:118), which is shown by the contrast between the infelicitous # *Einstein hefur* [PRS.IND] *heimsótt* Princeton (# 'Einstein has visited Princeton.') and its unobjectionable conditional V1-counterpart *Hafi* [PRS.SUBJ] *Einstein heimsótt* Princeton,

⁴ Thráinsson (2019:627,fn.11) makes the interesting observation that colloquially, reportive *kveða* can be realized as invariant *ku*. This expression equally resists conditional inversion (**Ku sjálfur bréfberinn vera milljónamæringur, ...*).

⁵ Following Thráinsson (ibid.), such "innovative" uses are marked by %. Related variation is attested in the historical record of English (cf. Moessner 2020). For a recent study of L2 effects on mood choice in Icelandic child language, see Sigurjónsdóttir and Nowenstein (2021).

⁶ (10) stems from Grímnismál (stanza 53) of the Poetic Edda (cf. von See, La Farge and Schulz 2019:1468). See Larrington (2014) for a contemporary English translation.

⁷ Note the appeal to an attitude of wondering in view of a decision problem faced by an agent, which Kaufmann, Kaufmann and Hinterwimmer (2025) make in attempting to profile German *falls* ('in case') against *wenn* ('if'). These authors cross-reference work on German *sollte* ('should') (e.g., Sode and Sugawara 2019), which makes sense from our perspective, not the least since Gering and Sijmons (1927:215) employ *sollte* in their German translation of the conditional protasis in (10) in addition to rendering *ef* by *falls*.

⁸ This would be consistent with considering the (default) indicative requirement of *ef* [COND.O], introduced in (15b) below, a lexical idiosyncrasy (cf. Sigurðsson 2010:47), similar to what has been argued for Catalan *si* by Quer (2001:102,fn.23).

⁹ The latter so-called "domino-effect" (cf. Thráinsson 2007:398) can be seen in (i), built on a variant of (1a).

(i) *María segir að [ef hann hafi [PRS.SUBJ] farið, komi [PRS.SUBJ] hún]*

'Mary says that if he has left, she will come.'

By contrast, operations that otherwise may flip subjunctives into indicatives, like the marking of speaker commitments (cf. Sigurðsson 1990; 2010), have no effect on (15a). "Premise conditionals" (cf. Haegeman 2003), for example, obey CMS_1 in Icelandic despite the speaker's being committed to the truth of the protasis proposition.

¹⁰ We refrain from going into the controversy about "fake past" (e.g., Kaufmann 2023). Past subjunctives like *væri* can acquire past time reference anaphorically, as the following illustration of CMS_1 by Einarsson (1949:153) shows.

(i) a. *Hann fór alltaf, ef honum var boðið.*

he go.PST.IND always if he.DAT be.PST.IND invited

'He always went, if he was invited.'

b. *Væri honum boðið, fór hann alltaf.*

be.PST.SUBJ he.DAT invited go.PST.IND he always

'If he was invited, he always went.'

Here, a past shift has occurred in the (understood narrative) context.

¹¹ Once recognized for what it is, this effect can be demonstrated across the full range of configurations involving obligatory subjunctives, such as concessive clauses (cf. Sigurðsson 2010:46; Thráinsson 2007:404). (i) is a case in point.

(i) *María kemur í dag, þó að hún hafi verið / *væri í Danmörku í gær.*

Mary comes today although she have.PRS.SUBJ been be.PST.SUBJ in Denmark yesterday

'Mary is coming today although she was in Denmark yesterday.'

¹² By contrast, the standard *ef*-counterpart of (3b) (*Ef María hefur* [PRS.IND] *verið* í Danmörku í gær, ...) behaves like (4) in inducing the inferential reading, given availability of the simple past competitor.

¹³ For subcategorization features, see, e.g., Müller (2011:174,fn13). An anonymous reviewer alerted us to an example of reportive *kveða* in the shape of a present subjunctive (... *þótt nú kveði* [PRS.SUBJ] *vera stríð* ...; 'although there is said to be war now'), which satisfies the subjunctivity requirement of concessive *þótt* ('although'). This occurs in a 1944 contribution to the academic journal *Skírnir* (118:207-209) and seems to reflect a usage antedating the state reportive *kveða* has reached in contemporary Icelandic such as described here.